Project Requirements

McGill - COMP 765 - Fall 2026

November 2, 2026

The COMP 765 course project is intended as an end-stage (700-level) assessment which gives students room to explore beyond lecture content independently in the course topic, gain hands-on exposure to relevant research code and data and build on the seminar style of the course by sharing findings with peers.

Due to the research nature, the requirements and grading are by intention very flexible. The guiding rule is to pursue international-level research at the best level you can manage, for about 1 week of work time. Write a thoughtful report that uses good scientific practices to report your findings and present informatively in the interactive session.

Here are some general principles to keep in mind:

- State a goal or hypothesis that guides your efforts. Simply learning about the method you choose is often the major motivation, but as you get a bit of sophistication regarding the technique, I encourage you to at least pick a sub-part of the paper that you hope to examine most deeply and it is also quite reasonable to propose how to improve the method, even if the full implementation of the improvement takes too long for this project.

- Write a related work section in your own words. Do not copy/paste the text from your selected paper, even though your reference list should of course overlap the paper's original one strongly. Add some discussion of papers that have appeared *after the target paper was released* to update the references to the present time. Compare and contrast with work we've seen in class and papers your peers are presenting.

- Write a Method section that recaps that paper's techniques in your own words (do not copy/paste). Add detail that you explored that might go beyond the often-minimal analysis and proof that a short conference paper can fit in its original Method. Include technical support for your hypothesis.

- Do include data and findings. This can range from an Appendix with compilation failures and/or flat training results with your best analysis for why the provided code did not succeed. Of course it is ideal if you can get to the point where an appropriate empirical validation of your hypothesis is attempted.

- Write a conclusion that gives a wrap-up of your exploration of the hypothesis, and also highlights things you have learned, surprises, changed assumptions and open questions for you in this area.

Hand in the report PDF on the final day of classes, December 3rd, at 9pm on as a My Courses Assignment named "Final Project". Target 6-8 page conference paper length using a standard template (I prefer two column, but style is open to your preference).

The final lecture of term, also on Thursday December 3rd (note McGill's bizarre "Thursday is a Monday" scheduling that week...) will be an interactive presentation session. Bring your laptop, some images, or whatever you can manage to show your findings to other students. There will not be sufficient time for everyone to give a full Powerpoint presentation, so rather the format will be to have stations with presenters seated and showing a group 1-2 slides or some videos while doing Q&A.

The default model is that each student does and independent project for this class only. However, teams of up to 2 can be possible and doing similar material in another class' project and submitting separate reports can be explored, but those plans should get explicit verbal approval from the instructor and must have a clear plan for avoiding self-plagarism and keep a balance of work between students and classes.